



State Learning Collaborative Application 2021 - 2022

IMPORTANT NOTE: The information in this document is for informational purposes only to assist in development of applications. Applications must be submitted online at [this link](#). No other submissions will be accepted.

Background

IT'S EMPLOYMENT is a Rehabilitation Services Administration (RSA) funded effort to improve employment outcomes for individuals with intellectual disabilities (ID) through training of vocational rehabilitation personnel, including staff who work for state vocational rehabilitation agencies, other public systems, and service providers. This project is operated by the Institute for Community Inclusion at the University of Massachusetts Boston. Among the variety of training initiatives under this project, ICI is working with selected states on development of a State Learning Collaborative (SLC).

State learning collaboratives will work to increase the capacity of public vocational rehabilitation agencies (VR) to meet the employment needs of individuals with intellectual disabilities (ID) through enhancing knowledge of VR staff and partners and strengthening of partnerships. Over the course of a year, each selected agency will receive 2 full days of training (or equivalent online), customized to the state's specific needs, with a follow-up Community of Practice meeting remotely approximately once per month over 6 months.

State Learning Collaborative

General Information

- The SLC is a training and staff development project. In their applications, states should focus on proposed topics, goals, and activities that can be reasonably addressed within two days of training (or online equivalent) and the 6 Community of Practice sessions. Examples of topics that can be addressed through participation in the SLC include: job development and job supports for people with ID; effective rehabilitation counseling and case management for individuals with ID; integrating self-determination and informed choice within services; transition from school to employment; effective engagement of families; strengthening of partnerships; effective management and supports for service providers; customized employment; accommodations and assistive technology for individuals with ID. Note that

these are just examples, and states should identify areas that address specific needs within their states.

- ICI staff time, support, and travel are paid for through grant funds and are provided at no charge. For in-person training, each state will be responsible for paying for all associated costs beyond the development and delivery of the training (meeting space, meals, refreshments, travel for training participants, etc.).
- Each year, two states are selected for the SLC. States not selected in one year may apply again in subsequent years.
- The application deadline is Friday August 20, 2021, 8:00 pm eastern. Agencies will be notified on the status of their application by September 10, 2021. Initial meetings with states accepted will take place in October 2021.

Informational webinar and questions

This application contains detailed information regarding the State Learning Collaborative initiative. In addition, on Thursday August 5th from 3:00 to 4:00 pm ET there will be an informational webinar on the SLC initiative for potential applicants. Register for this webinar at [this link](#). If you have any questions regarding this initiative, please contact David Hoff at david.hoff@umb.edu or 617-480-9230.

Structure

Each state will develop a team to be engaged in the State Learning Collaborative. The vocational rehabilitation agency must be the applicant and serve as lead. The state's intellectual and developmental disability agency is a required partner. Additional partners may also be included based on the state's specific goals for improving employment services and outcomes for individuals with intellectual disabilities. The focus of this effort is intended to have impact on a statewide level. If a Tribal Vocational Rehabilitation Agency is the applicant, the focus of the SLC will be on the region covered by that agency.

Activities

The following outlines the process for each participating agency.

1. Leadership Team: Each VR agency selected will identify a leadership team for the SLC. This leadership team will serve as the coordinating body for the SLC. Along with VR agency staff, a representative from your state's intellectual and developmental disability agency is a required member of the leadership team. States are also encouraged to include representatives from other entities that can assist the VR agency in meeting its objectives for SLC participation.
2. Needs assessment: Based on the information provided in its application, staff from the Institute for Community Inclusion (ICI) will work with each SLC leadership team to assess the specific needs for increased staff knowledge and competency in meeting the needs of individuals with intellectual disabilities.
3. Training: Based on the results of the needs assessment, a 2-day in-person training (or online equivalent of approximately 12-14 hours total) will be developed, to be delivered by ICI

staff. The training will be customized to each SLC's needs, in terms of content, structure, number of attendees, etc. Each SLC will identify potential attendees for the training, and work with ICI on outreach and training registration, and training logistics. For in-person training, the SLC will be responsible for identifying an appropriate location and covering all related costs.

4. Community of Practice: After the training is completed, a follow-up Community of Practice will be conducted with the leadership team and other selected individuals who attended the training. The intent of this Community of Practice is to follow up on the content from the training, and work with the SLC on implementation. The Community of Practice will consist of 6 online calls approximately once per month facilitated by ICI staff.

Expected Outcomes

The State Learning Collaborative has been designed to assist VR agencies, in collaboration with partners, to increase their ability to meet the employment needs of individuals with intellectual disabilities. Each VR agency is expected to identify goals for the project that will ultimately lead to:

- Enhanced competencies and skills in meeting the employment needs of individuals with intellectual disabilities.
- A sustained and enhanced partnership between VR and other agencies to support employment of individuals with intellectual disabilities.
- Increases in number of individuals with intellectual disabilities determined eligible by the VR agency.
- Increases in number of individuals with intellectual disabilities served by the VR agency.
- Increases in number of individuals with intellectual disabilities in competitive integrated employment.

Application Requirements and Criteria

Required Applicant: State Public Vocational Rehabilitation Agency or Tribal Vocational Rehabilitation Agency

Required partner: State Intellectual and Developmental Disability Agency

Optional partners:

- Education
- Provider agencies
- Provider network/association
- Workforce agency
- Inclusive higher education program
- Self-advocacy groups
- Business groups
- Policy leaders
- Developmental Disabilities Council
- State committees on employment

- Tribal groups
- Others

Criteria for selection of agencies

Agencies will be selected according to the following criteria:

- Commitment to improving employment outcomes for individuals with intellectual disabilities.
- Areas of need, focus and goals are likely to positively impact outcomes for individuals with intellectual disabilities over time.
- Proposed focus can be reasonably addressed with the resources available from the State Leadership Collaborative.
- Commitment of state intellectual and developmental disability agency as a partner.
- Commitment to participate in and complete all project activities by September 30, 2022.
- Ability to sustain systematic improvement in employment of individuals with ID.

Application Instructions

NOTE: The information in this document is for informational purposes only. Applications must be submitted online at [this link](#).

1) Complete application form narrative: Answer all questions on the application form on the following pages.

2) Provide required attachments:

- Letter of commitment from the state intellectual and developmental disability agency.
- Current memorandum of understanding with the state intellectual and developmental disability agency.

3) Provide optional attachments: Additional letters of commitment from other project partners may be provided but are not required.

Application Information

- Name of agency applying and lead contact (name, phone, email).
- Please list any additional agencies or organizations who will be members of the SLC Leadership Team (agency, contact name, email, phone).

Application Questions

- What are your proposed focused areas for the 2 days of in-person training (or 12 to 14 hour equivalent online) and 6 Community of Practice follow up sessions? How will these particular focus areas increase your ability to meet the employment needs of individuals with intellectual disabilities? (3,000 characters maximum)
- Describe your current efforts regarding employment of individuals with intellectual disabilities. (3,000 characters maximum)

3. Describe your current partnership with your state intellectual and developmental disability agency. (3,000 characters maximum)
 4. What strengths does your VR agency, and state as a whole have in serving people with intellectual disabilities? (3,000 characters maximum)
 5. What challenges does your VR agency and state as a whole have in serving people with intellectual disabilities? (3,000 characters maximum)
 6. What are your short-term goals for participation in the SLC? (1,800 characters maximum)
 7. What is your expected long-term impact for participation in the SLC? (1,800 characters maximum)
 8. How will you sustain your efforts after your participation in the SLC ends? (3,000 characters maximum)
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Data

Please provide the following data for the most recent two years available. (ID = Intellectual Disability). Note: If possible, please obtain this data from your state data system. If this is not available, data through 2018 is available at: <https://www.statedata.info>

1. Total # of all closures
 2. Total # of closures with ID
 3. All closures into an employment setting
 4. Closures with ID into an employment setting
 5. All closures with an IPE but no employment outcome
 6. Closures with ID and an IPE but no employment outcome
 7. Rehabilitation rate for all closures with an IPE
 8. Rehabilitation rate for all closures with ID
 9. Percentage of all closures into employment
 10. Percentage of all closures with ID into employment
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Submission statements

Through submission of this application, if selected to participate in the SLC, the applicant and partners commit to the following:

- ✓ Full participation in all SLC activities, including 2-day training and Community of Practice.
 - ✓ Completion of SLC activities by September 30, 2022
 - ✓ Full responsibility for all costs associated with the in-person 2-day training including but not limited to meeting space, meals refreshments, travel for training attendees.
 - ✓ Full participation in all evaluation activities associated with the SLC.
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